

Reading Math through Truth: An Interpretive Proposal on the Fourth Branch

A single constraint on false representation, argued from the whole of the Fourth Branch

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The question this essay puts is deliberately modest. Given the acknowledged hazards of reconstructing pre-Christian material from the Fourth Branch of the Mabinogi, does reading the figure of Math through truth account for more of the surviving portrait, with fewer independent assumptions, than the principal alternatives? More precisely, it proposes that the recurrent operations attributed to Math are governed by a single constraint, a constraint on false representation that holds at his borders in both directions, so that falsehood asserted to him does not survive the assertion and falsehood is never worked by his own characteristic instrument, and asks whether that logic of truth accounts for the operations attributed to him; it begins from an observable textual mechanism and only afterwards asks what reconstruction, if any, should follow. The proposal has a weaker and a stronger form, and it is written so that the weaker form, that truth has been underweighted as an organising principle for the figure, can stand even if the stronger, reconstructive form is not granted.

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1. The figure and the state of interpretation

Math fab Mathonwy is the eponymous figure of the Fourth Branch of the Mabinogi, preserved in the White Book of Rhydderch and the Red Book of Hergest, with a few earlier fragments. The tale is agreed to be older than the manuscripts, though how much older is disputed.¹ The branch is edited by Williams and, for Math specifically, by Hughes, and translated by Davies among others.²

Within the branch Math is lord of Gwynedd and a magician of great power, bound to rest his feet in the lap of a virgin footholder except in war. When his nephews Gwydion and Gilfaethwy contrive the rape of his footholder Goewin, he weds Goewin to restore her standing and drives the offenders three years through animal forms, compelled to mate and bear young; with Gwydion he later fashions Blodeuwedd from flowers for Lleu, and with his rod exposes Aranrhod's false claim.

Interpretation of the figure runs along several tendencies rather than dividing into fixed schools. A reconstructive tendency, whose fullest statement remains that of Gruffydd, reads the Branches as euhemerised mythology and takes figures such as Math to be deities reduced, under Christian transmission, to legendary kings and ancestral names.³ It should be said at once that this tendency is the one the field has moved furthest away from, and that the movement is not a matter of fashion but of argument; see note 5. Two further tendencies must be told apart, since they are often run together and only one of them is a sovereignty reading. There is the older sovereignty criticism descending from Mac Cana, on which the footholder is a token of sovereignty and royal purity and Math an image of sacred kingship. And there is a distinct and recent revisionist reading, given its fullest statement for this branch by McKenna, which is not a sovereignty reading at all: she sets out to revise the consensus that Math is a magnanimous and ideal king, reads him instead as a defective lord who must learn, and expressly resists a sovereignty-mythological account of the footholder on the ground of its circularity.⁴ Her conclusion is political and didactic, that the branch harnesses inherited material to instruct rulers in the conduct of lordship. It should be said at once that the footholder office is itself attested, as a court functionary, in the medieval Welsh laws, where the jurists have no doubt whatever that the officer is male; the female footholder of the branch is thus already a literary departure, and the sovereignty reading a layer of interpretation upon a worldly office.⁵ A more skeptical tendency, associated with the Celtosceptic turn in the field, is wary of reconstructing pre-Christian material from such texts at all.⁶ These are emphases that coexist, often within a single reader, not three camps that exhaust the field.

Any proposal must be set against this background, and with its first hazard admitted plainly: the medieval text is very nearly our only substantial witness, and whether a coherent pre-Christian figure stands behind it is itself contested.

2. A reading of the extant figure (primary text)

The first and more secure part of the proposal is a reading of the surviving figure, and it can be assessed without any reconstruction. Three capacities attach to Math persistently in the branch: magic, discernment, and judgement. The proposal is that these are not three coordinate powers but aspects of one, and that the organising term beneath them is truth. Discernment is the plainest case, for what the branch shows is not neutral perception but the detecting of what is truly so beneath what is claimed, which is truth in its receptive form. Math's defining supernatural

attribute belongs here, and it must be stated with more care than it has usually been given: he is said to know whatever is spoken between people if the wind meets it, a trait the tradition itself likens to the all-hearing Coraniaid.⁷ The branch does not independently establish the reach of this characteristic, and this essay does not attempt to settle it; what follows asks instead whether the distribution of speech around Math exhibits a related constraint. Judgement, likewise, is not primarily characterised through formal adjudication; its most revealing instances occur through disclosure and transformation, as in the rod-test that undoes Aranrhod's claim to virginity in the very act of examining it,⁸ which is truth in its exposing form. And his magic, in its most characteristic use, is not the generative art it is in Gwydion's hands but its complement, the making-unavoidable of what is the case. If that reading holds, truth is not a fourth item added to the inventory but the principle the other three severally express.

The correction of Gwydion and Gilfaethwy is the fullest single instance of this, and it is worth stating with care, because the reading needs less of it than might be thought.⁹ Math turns the brothers into deer, boar and wolf, and the decisive point is the plainest one: he makes them genuinely those beasts, he does not make them seem so. Actuality is changed, and appearance answers to the change; no gap is opened between seeming and being. That is all the truth-reading needs from the episode, and it needs no claim that the brothers were somehow already those beasts. A richer reading is available and may deepen the episode, that the forms they are made to wear answer to a moral reality their conduct had made true of them, so that the change discloses as much as it imposes; but that reading is optional, and nothing rests on it. Read at either depth, Math and Gwydion stand as complements, and the contrast is sharper than transformation against revelation: Gwydion can change being and seeming independently, and so can make the false seem true; Math changes being but never leaves seeming false to it. This depends on no reconstruction whatever, and if it holds, truth, in the sense of that integrity between appearance and actuality, is the economical principle organising the capacities named above, and the weaker form of the thesis follows: truth has been underweighted, relative to kingship and to magic, as the organising centre of the extant Math.

The attribute of hearing needs its own treatment, because an objection lies against it that goes to the best evidence the reading has. McKenna observes that the branch makes comic use of the attribute at the moment it is announced: Gilfaethwy will not confess his trouble on the ground that Math hears whatever the wind meets, whereupon Gwydion says the thing aloud and Math, to all appearances, does not hear it. She takes the motif to have been chosen with ironic intent, since Math proves ignorant of his nephews' designs, of the deceit by which the swine were got, of Pryderi's outrage, and of the invasion until the eleventh hour.¹⁰ Her observation is exact, and we accept it entire against one reading of the attribute, the reading on which the attribute yields Math a general knowledge of what is going on around him. That the branch plainly does not bear out, and this essay does not defend it. But three propositions must be told apart before the concession is measured, because they are not the same and the branch does not treat them alike: that Math hears whatever is spoken; that Math knows what is the case; and that Math acts upon whatever he hears. Her examples bear decisively upon the second. They bear upon the first only if what he was ignorant of had been spoken within reach of him, and upon the third not at all, since a lord who hears something and does nothing has not thereby failed to hear it. Ignorance establishes that he is not omniscient. It does not by itself establish that speech escaped him, because ignorance may arise as well from what was never said, from a purpose withheld behind true statements, or from a failure to act on what was heard. It is worth noting that the inference she draws from the scene is

not compelled by the passage. Hughes, editing these lines, records the same juxtaposition, that the characteristic makes it dangerous for Gilfaethwy to speak and that Gwydion immediately speaks anyway, and concludes only that Gwydion appears unafraid of the consequences of speaking aloud.

¹¹ He does not infer that Math failed to hear. The announcing scene, which is the strongest form of the objection because the attribute is punctured in the very breath that declares it, ceases on this account to be a counterexample to the reading, though it does not positively establish it either, since the same non-reaction would fit Math's simply not hearing the words. What Gwydion says aloud is that Gilfaethwy loves Goewin, and it is true. A border set against falsehood has nothing to seize in a true statement, so Math's silence there is not the attribute failing but the attribute idle for want of anything false to catch, which is precisely how a power over falsehood meets the truth. Whether he heard the words and let them pass, or never received them, the text leaves undecidable, and for this reading it does not matter: a truth was spoken, and truth is the one thing that gives a power over falsehood nothing to answer. This essay therefore does not claim that the attribute is less than it says, and does not need to; what it claims is about the fate of falsehood, and that claim is indifferent to how far the hearing reaches.

The catalogue of ignorances then reads differently. A design kept to oneself is not an assertion; a deceit worked upon Pryderi in Ceredigion is not an assertion made to Math; an outrage felt in Dyfed and an army on the march are events and not statements. Gwydion, notably, tells Math nothing false about the swine at any point, and conceals only the purpose the errand is to serve. Not one item in the catalogue is a false assertion made to Math. Set against that, the branch contains exactly one such assertion, Aranrhod's answer when she is asked whether she is a maiden, and it is undone in the act of its testing. We do not claim that a single instance establishes a rule, and the weight here is not carried by Aranrhod. It is carried by the distribution: a branch that deploys false assertion freely and to great effect, in an author who plainly commands the device, never once shows it succeeding against Math. The falsifier is correspondingly plain, and we state it in advance. One surviving instance of a false assertion made to Math which succeeds and is never exposed would break this.

Two things must be conceded before that distribution is put to work, and conceded here rather than left for a reader to find. The first is that the characteristic is declared once and is never shown operating. Everything Math is shown to know in the branch he learns by report or by enacted test, and at the moment where a wind-borne faculty would serve best, the narrator says instead that the tale went to Math.¹² So the attribute is narratively inert, which is a stronger and more specific version of what McKenna noticed. The second follows from it: the distribution below is not offered as an interpretation of what the characteristic secretly means. Its lexical sense is hearing, and Hughes's gloss gives no reason to reinterpret it. What is claimed is a convergence and not an identification. The text marks Math as extraordinarily open to what is spoken; the distribution of speech around him exhibits a constraint on falsehood; the reconstruction proposed later joins the two under one principle. Neither is used to prove the other.

A related distribution belongs beside it, because it is checkable and because it does not depend on any view of what Math is. Gwydion employs false assertion repeatedly and elaborately against Pryderi and against Aranrhod. Against Math he never employs it at all; in dealing with his uncle he relies instead on true statements, on omission, and on concealed purpose. The same man, the same art, and a method that changes according to whom he faces. That the method is calibrated to

something in Math's nature, rather than to prudence about a powerful kinsman, is our inference and is marked as such; the distribution itself is a fact about the text.

A further observation belongs beside this, textual and checkable, and it is worth stating so that it assumes nothing it means to show. Across the whole branch the magic divides by instrument. The deceptive and generative magic, the horses conjured from fungus, the phantom fleet, the ship, the flower-woman, is always worked bare-handed, without the wand; the wand attends only operations that are non-illusory and materially effective, and never once a false appearance. This absence is bounded, and so is evidence rather than mere silence: deception recurs through the branch, giving the author every occasion to set the wand to it, and the wand is never so used. Put schematically, across the complete surviving text, wand-magic is always a materially effective, non-illusory operation, and illusion is always wandless.

What unites the wand's operations is cleaner than correspondence with some prior reality, and it does not require the brothers' transformation to be defended as revelatory. It is that whatever the wand makes real is real: after it acts, what appears to be the case is the case. On this the operations divide without strain. The rod discloses a concealed fact, Aranrhod's condition. The restorations make an original condition real again. The transformation of the brothers makes a new condition genuinely so: Math does not make Gwydion seem a stag, he makes him one. Even a creation from nothing would fit, were the branch to show the wand doing it, provided what is made genuinely exists, for there would still be no deception. The single operation that would break the pattern is the one the wand is never given, illusion, in which appearance and actuality come apart. So the defining constraint is not that the wand reveals what is already true but that it never lies: it may disclose, restore, transform, perhaps even create, and in every case what it makes is truly so. The richer reading that the brothers wear a moral reality already theirs, argued above, may still hold and deepen the episode, but the wand-pattern stands entirely without it, on the plain fact that the transformation is real and not a false seeming.

Two clarifications sharpen this. By "real" nothing metaphysical is intended, only the distinction the tales themselves draw: the resulting state is actual within the story rather than a mere seeming, as Gwydion's vanishing horses and phantom fleet are seemings. And the rule is falsifiable in a precise and useful way, for it says in advance what would break it. The damaging counterexample is not Math creating something new, nor his transforming something drastically, since neither is a lie; it is a single surviving instance in which Math's characteristic wand produces an appearance the narrative establishes is not actually so. One clear such case would break the rule. Read whole, the branch offers none: every wand-operation makes actuality, and every seeming that is false to being is worked without the wand.

Set beside the speech-distribution, the wand completes a shape worth drawing out, for the two findings are not merely cumulative. They have the same evidential form and run in opposite directions. Toward Math, in speech, false assertion exists freely in the branch and never successfully crosses to him. From Math, by instrument, false appearance exists freely in the branch and is never once produced by his wand. In both cases the falsehood is demonstrably available to the author, is used elsewhere to great effect, and is absent at exactly one place; and in both cases concealment remains entirely possible, because concealment is not falsehood. Math can be kept ignorant, and Math is nowhere obliged to disclose. What is claimed is therefore neither omniscience nor compulsory disclosure, but a constraint upon false representation holding at his border in both directions. One power, two directions of travel, and no second sphere added. This is

also why the capacities older readings filed as separate, discernment, judgement, magic, take the particular forms they do, for they are one truth met at different bearings. Incoming, an assertion that is false does not survive being made to him; outgoing, what he makes so is so; and at the border, the exposed falsehood draws consequence. Put this way the proposal no longer merely gathers characteristics under an attractive word; it says why differently-shaped capacities belong to one figure, and why each has the shape it has.

This extant-text argument stands on its own. Nothing in the comparative and reconstructive material that follows is needed to sustain it, and should that material fail, this reading of the surviving figure remains.

3. The reconstructive step (inference)

The stronger form of the proposal goes beyond the text, and should be marked as doing so. If one adopts the reconstructive premise and asks after a pre-Christian figure behind the branch, the reading above suggests a direction, but a further premise must be introduced explicitly here, because it is not one the evidence can independently demonstrate. If such a figure is reconstructed not as a personification that stands for truth but as an ontological power of which truth is the consequence, then the proposed direction is that where the power is, no falsehood finally holds, rather than that the power symbolises a value called truth. This is the point at which the metaphysics of our wider project enters, and a reader may decline the ontological premise and still keep the reading of Section 2 entire.

On that premise, kingship is not a further attribute of the figure but the most transmitted-through element of the portrait. A power met by human societies chiefly at its edge, where falsehood crossing it yields judgement and consequence, could readily be represented by transmitters working in a courtly milieu through the available idiom of dynastic and courtly kingship; and a figure so represented could come to stand in the record as a king. The claim required is only the weak one, that such an idiom was available and natural to the transmitters, not the strong and indefensible claim that they possessed no other conceptual vocabulary. That weak claim need not rest on our own authority. McKenna establishes that the lawbooks and the Branches arise from overlapping learned circles, lawyers, poets and *cyfarwyddiaid*, which drew upon a common body of inherited material and reshaped it for their own purposes.¹³ We take that to supply the premise, and to supply it with a mechanism: a learned class demonstrably in the habit of taking what it had inherited and refashioning it in the courtly idiom of its own institutional imagination.

Here the proposal meets a specific and recent interlocutor rather than a diffuse tendency, and the first thing to establish is that we are not answering the same question. McKenna's study sets out to revise the consensus that Math is a magnanimous and ideal king, and reads him instead as a lord who must become what he needs to be, afflicted at the outset by a species of sloth that leaves his militia unsupervised, his ally deceived in his name, and his own household violated.¹⁴ Her object is the function of Math's rulership within the surviving branch, and her conclusion is that the resources of native tradition are harnessed there to instruct rulers in prudence and dignity.¹⁵ That is an inquiry into what this text does with the figure it inherited. The inquiry of this section is a different one, into what the inherited figure may have been. The two are adjacent and can both be right, and this essay does not need to defeat her in order to proceed.

The distinction matters for a reason of method rather than of tact. If Math's lordship in the surviving branch has a demonstrable medieval literary and political function, as she shows it has, then that lordship cannot also be treated as evidence for what the figure was before the branch put it to that use, since to do so would be to read a feature of the transmission product back into the object transmitted. The reconstruction accordingly does not admit kingship to its evidence at all. This is not a claim that Math's kingship was added late, which we could not show. It is the narrower claim that nothing presently licenses projecting it backwards, and it carries the consequence that Math's failures as a ruler, which McKenna documents at length and which we do not dispute, bear upon his competence in the role the branch gives him and not upon the reconstruction offered here. What would bear upon the reconstruction is a successful lie to Math, and that is a different proposition altogether.

Two of her findings then do real work for this essay, neither framed with it in view. She establishes, from the Laws of Court and their recent critical scrutiny, that the footholder's office in its legal form is worldly and courtly rather than sacral or hieratic.¹⁶ We accept that without qualification; it tells against the sovereignty account of the footholder and costs this reading nothing, since this reading has never required the office to be sacral. And she observes, while arguing something else, that Gwydion's conjured horses revert to the toadstools they were made from whereas Math's transformations hold until he lifts them himself, which she reads as evidence of the greater power by which Math re-establishes his kingship.¹⁷ We suggest the contrast will not bear a reading in degree, and the text is firmer on the point than the comparison she draws from it: Gwydion says outright that his enchantment will not last beyond the hour, while the wand's transformations hold until they are deliberately lifted.¹⁸ Duration is the wrong measure for a stronger power, since a stronger illusion would last longer rather than cease to be an illusion. On our reading she has observed, and set to other work, a temporal test of exactly the distinction between actuality and appearance on which the argument below turns. She is cited here for that observation and never for the use we make of it.

The comparative Celtic material, examined more fully than the ruler's truth alone, supports the reading rather than confining it to sovereignty, provided it is drawn at the right level. Early Irish tradition, and behind it Indo-European tradition, preserves what Dillon and Watkins term the Act of Truth: the pronouncement of a truth that effects a change in the physical or social world.¹⁹ Its royal form is *fir flathemon*, the ruler's truth, classically expressed in *Audacht Morainn*, through which the land has peace and plenty and by whose failure it suffers plague and dearth; but the tradition also knows a non-royal *fir filed*, the truth of poets. This shows that effective truth, in which a truthful declaration or condition has consequences in the world, was available within early Irish learned tradition and has wider Indo-European comparanda; whether that conception provides a legitimate comparandum for the Welsh Math is a separate question, to be argued and not assumed. What it settles immediately is only the narrow point that the objection that our truth is merely the ruler's truth in another dress does not hold, since the Act of Truth is not confined to kings.

The comparison must also be pitched at the right concept, for the Act of Truth and the reading of Math are adjacent but not identical. The Act of Truth concerns truth's efficacy, a true assertion or condition effecting something in the world; the reading of Math concerns truth's power over the integrity of appearance and actuality: concealed actuality may be disclosed, an existing form restored, or actuality itself transformed, but in every case the resulting appearance answers to what

is genuinely so. The claim is therefore not that Math performs an Irish Act of Truth, but that the Irish evidence attests a wider conceptual possibility, in which truth is causally efficacious within reality rather than a passive correspondence to it, of which Math would be, if the comparison is accepted, a distinct Welsh literary configuration. That is a more modest and more defensible move than deriving a Celtic truth-theology from a shared motif. On the narrower doctrine of *fir flathemon* we accordingly claim only compatibility, and less is now needed from it than an earlier draft of this essay supposed. Since the reconstruction does not admit kingship to its evidence, it has no relation between truth and kingship to settle, and the Irish royal doctrine is not required to show that truth is prior to sovereignty. Its value here is the narrower and firmer one, that early Insular thought could conceive truth as efficacious rather than merely descriptive; and the non-royal *fir filed* matters for the same reason, that the conception is not confined to kings.

One line of the reconstruction builds directly on that distribution, and it runs forward at every step without the insecure premise that an object can have no powers of its own, which in a magical tale it plainly can. It has four moves. First, the textual observation: every surviving use of Math's wand produces actuality, and none produces mere appearance. Second, the comparative observation: the same branch is full of deceptive and illusory magic, so its author plainly commands the distinction between changing what is and falsifying how it seems. Third, the inference: a distribution that holds across the whole text, in an author who knows the difference and had every occasion to breach it, is therefore likely to be characterising rather than a mere limit of the tale's magical vocabulary. The branch itself corroborates the classification from a second and quite different kind of evidence, and states the rule rather than leaving it to inference: the conjured horses and hounds are made from toadstools, and Gwydion says of them that the enchantment will not last beyond the hour, whereas every transformation the wand effects holds until it is deliberately lifted.²⁰ Fourth, the reconstruction, which is the strong claim: the wand behaves exactly as an instrument of Truth should, free to disclose, restore, transform, and perhaps create, but unable to make what is not so appear to be so. Every step runs from the text toward the conclusion, and none assumes it.

This sharpens the relation of the two brothers beyond a crude opposition of truth and illusion. Both transform reality; the difference is that Gwydion can also make the false seem true and Math, on the surviving evidence, cannot. Read reconstructively, Math is Truth and Gwydion is Transformation: transformation is in itself indifferent to truth, able to make reality, alter it, or counterfeit it, and dangerous precisely because nothing in it requires appearance to answer to actuality; truth can transform too, but it cannot deceive. That is why the wand sits so naturally with Math, and the point is reached without assuming at the outset that Math is Truth, for the textual rule comes first, that his wand makes actuality and never appearance, and the naming of the power only follows it.

It is worth adding, though only as far as it bears, that the extant figure has not been reduced to a plain mortal ruler. Several more-than-human traits survive in it, unequal in force but cumulative: the attribute of hearing whatever the wind carries, plainly supernatural; an enchantment proverbial enough to stand among the Three Great Enchantments of the Island, and attested for Math well outside this branch, in the Triads, in the Book of Taliesin, and among the storytellers of the period in which the Branches were written down;²¹ the life bound to a condition, which we now mark undecided rather than count in our favour, since McKenna offers both a grammatical alternative to the existential reading and an intelligible literary use for the condition as it stands, and we cannot presently choose between inheritance and literary purpose here;²² and, more

weakly, on the doubled-name reading below, a parentage that may be manufactured from his own name. Together these make a more-than-human figure secure; individually none demonstrates a former god, and we do not offer them as proof of one. Their force is of a different kind. If potentially divine material reached the manuscripts through the long transmission this reconstruction presupposes, an inherited god whose stories went on being told would be expected to survive not as a god openly named but as just such a figure: an extraordinary magician-lord carrying anomalies that ordinary kingship does not quite explain. The residue is therefore the form the reconstruction would predict, which is weaker than proof but stronger than noticing supernatural details and calling them survivals after the fact.

This reconstructive step carries costs we do not minimise, though two have eased. The footholder, which has a genuine institutional basis in the laws, must be shown not to belong to the theological core, and the concession is larger after McKenna than before her, since she establishes that the office in its legal form is not merely institutional but demonstrably courtly and non-sacral. We do not resist this, because the reading never needed the office to be sacral, and saying so plainly removes a target rather than defending one. What survives her is the double transformation itself, of sex and of significance, which any reading must account for; note 4 sets out the four accounts on offer and declines to add a fifth, since a reading of the office is an account of what the branch does with the figure and not of the figure this essay reconstructs. And the reading of Mathonwy is genuinely open between two options. On one it is a matronymic, suiting the matrilinear framing of the House of Don, whose sons are named for their mother. On the other, which we prefer, Mathonwy is a non-person, a doublet of Math's own name, in the manner of the invented pairs elsewhere in the tradition, Sugn son of Sugnydd, Drem son of Dremidydd; this reading is advanced by Davies with those very parallels, so it is no longer our conjecture alone.²³ What Davies establishes, however, is the doublet, not the process that produced it, for a doubled name may arise through literary genealogy, scribal interpretation, or narrative convention without preserving the demotion of a god. So the inference is kept in steps: if Mathonwy is a doublet, that is compatible with genealogisation, a human descent acquired by something that once needed none; and genealogisation is the kind of transformation one would expect under the diminishment that frames this reconstruction. On that chain of inference, and only as that, the name would be a small instance of the lowering the reconstruction posits, not a proof of it.

Finally, the wand-distribution is best seen as one strand of a convergence that is itself becoming the argument, and the strands are worth counting honestly, since a convergence is worth only what the independence of its members is worth. An earlier draft of this essay counted six. Tested rather than asserted, the count does not hold at six: the rod-test and the pattern of judgement are substantially one body of evidence described twice, and the attribute of hearing cannot be counted as a strand at all, since the branch never shows it operating and this essay does not treat the speech-distribution as its interpretation. Three strands survive that test. An earlier version counted a fourth, the limit at which a wrong done is compensated and never undone. It is withdrawn: nothing anywhere in the Four Branches undoes a past event, for any figure, so Math's inability to do so does not distinguish him and cannot be evidence of his nature. It is a consequence of the reading, and Section 4 now presents it as one. There is the speech-distribution, that no false assertion made to Math is shown succeeding, of which the rod-test is the single positive instance. There is the instrument-distribution, that the wand produces actuality and never appearance, corroborated in a second evidential form by the durability contrast and therefore partly rather than wholly independent of it. And there is the operation of restoration, which recovers a true form.

Three strands are fewer than six and worth more, because they are strands of genuinely different kinds, a distribution of speech-acts, a distribution of instrument-uses, and a discrete operation; and because their agreement is therefore not one interpretive assumption counted three times. Independent convergence, not density, is what does the evidential work, and where a strand is only partly independent we have said so.

4. The tragic limit: a consequence, not a proof

One feature of the branch tells in the reading's favour without flattering it. Math's correction of the wrong to Goewin, however exact, does not repair her: she is wedded, avenged, and restored in standing, and was still violated, and nothing the figure commands undoes it. A power organised around truth would have precisely this limit, for truth can reveal, correct, expose, and re-establish, and cannot heal a harm once done. On the stronger reading the limit sharpens and ceases to be mere impotence before harm. Math can change actuality, transform and perhaps make; what he cannot do, being Truth, is make the violated past cease to be the truth of what occurred, for to make it appear never to have happened would itself be the one lie truth cannot tell. So the tragedy would follow from his nature and not from any weakness: truth can change what is, and cannot change what was into what was not. We offer that as the reconstruction's account of the limit rather than a claim the episode by itself establishes, since we cannot say the branch shows he could otherwise have repaired her; but if the reconstruction holds, the limit is intrinsic, not incidental. A reading that yielded a benevolent sovereign of order, mending what was broken, would be the more suspect for its comfort; the figure the branch presents is harder, and colder: exacting but limited, able to reveal, correct, and restore standing, and unable to repair. That the reading is content to end there is not evidence for it, but it is a sign that it follows the text rather than improving on it.

5. What is claimed, and what is not

We claim, in the weaker form, that truth is the most economical principle organising the persistent capacities of the extant Math, and that it has been underweighted in favour of kingship and of magic; this is a reading of the surviving text, open to ordinary scholarly dispute over the episodes it rests on. We claim, in the stronger and more conjectural form, that if a pre-Christian figure is reconstructed behind the branch, truth is the best candidate for the inherited core, with kingship belonging to the branch's use of the figure rather than to the figure reconstructed; this depends on the reconstructive premise and on the ontological premise marked in Section 3, and carries the costs set out there. The article would succeed, we think, even if only the weaker form were granted, for to show that truth has been underweighted as an organising principle in the interpretation of Math is itself a contribution, independent of whether the strong claim is accepted. Whether the economy the reading offers is worth its costs is a question we would put to the field rather than settle here.

It may help, finally, to state the shape the reading has reached, since it has become more than a single equation of Math with truth. Truth received: no false assertion is shown surviving contact with him. Truth discerned: the one such assertion the branch contains is undone in the act of its testing. Truth enacted: what his characteristic instrument makes apparent is actually so. Truth judicial: once falsehood is exposed, consequence follows. Truth limited: what has truly happened cannot simply be made never to have happened. The first four are anchored in different parts of the

surviving portrait: a whole-text distribution of speech, an episode, a whole-text distribution of instrument-use, and a stretch of conduct. The fifth is of a different kind and is not offered as evidence. Since no figure anywhere in the Four Branches undoes a past event, Math's inability to do so tells us nothing about Math; it is stated as what the proposed nature would entail if the reading is accepted, not as a fact supporting it. Two things the reading does not claim should be said in the same breath, because both have been claimed for Math before and neither is defensible. It does not claim omniscience: he can be kept ignorant, and repeatedly is. It does not claim that he must disclose: concealment is not falsehood, and nothing in the reading obliges him to reveal. What is claimed throughout is a constraint upon false representation, and nothing wider. What the reading offers is therefore not merely a name for the figure but an account of what it would be for a power to be truth, and one generated by the peculiarities of Math's surviving behaviour rather than imposed upon them.

What the present argument requires from this note is only the negative point, and it is established without any of the five: the branch has transformed an attested office in two directions at once, of sex and of significance, and the law-code parallel is therefore not a sufficient account of Math's footholder. That much every reading above concedes.

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Research record

Before publication this argument was frozen and subjected to a hostile reading intended to falsify it rather than improve it. That read withdrew one evidential strand, raised a proposed counterexample which was then defeated by the primary text, and narrowed three further claims. The record is published in full as *Hostile Read: Reading Math through Truth*.

Changes in this version

Version 1, 30 August 2026. First publication.

Notes

1. The White Book of Rhydderch (Llyfr Gwyn Rhydderch) is dated c. 1350, the Red Book of Hergest (Llyfr Coch Hergest) c. 1382-1410, with fragments of some tales in earlier thirteenth-century manuscripts. The date of composition is unsettled. Ifor Williams argued for a date before 1100 on linguistic grounds (Williams 1930); Saunders Lewis proposed c. 1170-90; T. M. Charles-Edwards, weighing both, judged the language to fit best the eleventh century (Charles-Edwards 1971, 263-98); Sims-Williams contributed to the dating debate in Sims-Williams 1991. A range of roughly c. 1060-1200 is frequently cited in surveys, but there is no firm consensus: Andrew Breeze has argued for the 1120s-1130s (Breeze 2009), while others hold the exact date simply unknown, though certainly before the fall of Gwynedd in 1282. Sims-Williams's criticism of the bases of Charles-Edwards's dating is at "The Submission of Irish Kings in Fact and Fiction: Henry II, Bendigeidfran, and the Dating of *The Four Branches of the Mabinogi*," *Cambrian Medieval Celtic Studies* 22 (Winter 1991), 31-61; he advances no alternative date of his own. Charles-Edwards's range is proposed in "The Date of the Four Branches of the Mabinogi," *THSC* (1970), 263-98.↵
2. Standard edition of the Four Branches: Williams, *Pedeir Keinc y Mabinogi* (1930; 2nd ed. 1951). For the Fourth Branch specifically, Hughes, *Math uab Mathonwy* (Welsh-text edition 2000; edition with English introduction and notes 2013). Translation: Davies, *The Mabinogion* (2007).↵
3. Gruffydd, *Math vab Mathonwy* (1928), the fullest statement of the euhemerist reading of the Branches, which dismembers the tale into older, largely Irish themes (chiefly the Balor legends) and treats the figure named Math as the development of an original king, whom Gruffydd calls Beli (pp. 46, 49). The relation to the present proposal is instructive rather than simply supportive. Gruffydd too found the surviving human surface inadequate and sought divine material behind the branch; but where he dissolves Math into analogues and makes him peripheral, the tale being for him essentially the history of Lleu (pp. 54-55), the present reading treats Math as a coherent inherited figure in his own right. The two thus agree that divine material lies behind the branch and disagree over whether Math himself is such a figure, a sharper historiographical distinction than counting Gruffydd as evidence for divinity. Later scholarship has substantially qualified this "Old School," and that criticism should be represented here alongside the position itself.↵
4. McKenna, "Revising Math: Kingship in the Fourth Branch of the Mabinogi," *Cambrian Medieval Celtic Studies* 46 (2003): 95-118. Her stated aim is to revise the assessments of Roberts, Davies and Bollard, on which Math is magnanimous, fair and just, an ideal king, and to show instead the blemishes on the king's face (p. 95); her thesis is that he is better read as a lord in the process of becoming what he needs to be than as one who represents ideal kingship from the outset (p. 96), on the model of her readings of Pwyll (1980) and Manawydan (1999). The argument runs through the anomalous opening formula (pp. 97-99), the word *gwastadrwydd* and its negative colouring in *Ystorya Gereint uab Erbin* (pp. 99-101), a consuetudinal reading of *ny bydei uyw* (p. 102), and the Laws of Court on the *troediog* (pp. 104-107), to the diagnosis of Math's affliction as a moral one, a species of *acedia* (p. 108). On the sovereignty reading she is expressly resistant, finding Carey's account attractive but circular, since it is the text alone that provides the evidence of the myth which then explains the text (p. 103). Two of those steps are contested by the editor of the text, and one is corroborated, which a reader should know. Hughes glosses *y wastatrwyl* concretely, as "his permanent residence," citing McKenna at 99-102 for the alternative rather than adopting it; and he explains Math's not making the circuit of Gwynedd by the affliction itself rather than by any moral failing, so that where she

reads sloth he reads incapacity (Hughes, notes to line 10). Against that, he takes the position of *penteulu* to be held jointly by Gwydion and Gilfaethwy, which is her reading arrived at independently (note to line 12, citing Ior. section 6 and Carr, “Teulu and Penteulu,” WKC 142-66). This essay has no stake in adjudicating any of the three. The same “education of rulers” approach is represented by Fulton, “The Mabinogi and the Education of Princes in Medieval Wales” (2005).↵

5. For the sovereignty tendency see Mac Cana, *Branwen Daughter of Llyr* (Cardiff, 1958). Both this and Gruffydd’s reconstructive method belong to a phase of Celtic scholarship substantially qualified since, on the grounds set out in note 5; neither is cited here as an authority for the reconstruction, only as the position from which the present reading departs. The footholder office is attested in the medieval Welsh laws, in both the Cyfnerth and Iorwerth redactions: the officer sits beneath the king’s feet, holds them in his lap from the beginning of the feast until the king goes to sleep, scratches him, eats from the same dish with his back to the fire, and holds his land free and a horse from the king (Llyfr Iorwerth, ed. Wiliam, section 32, p. 18; trans. Jenkins, *The Law of Hywel Dda*, pp. 32-33, which is the clause Davies cites as LHDd 32-3; the same connection is drawn by Gruffydd 1928, p. 54 n. 6). McKenna quotes both redactions in full and draws the conclusions this note now relies on: that the jurists have no doubt whatever that the *troediog* is male, and male and wealthy, since he holds his office in right of land; and that the office is worldly and courtly rather than hieratic, its holder ranked among falconers, grooms, huntsmen, brewers, cooks and smiths, in a tractate Stacey describes as stylized, outrageously artificial, and even funny, and which Jenkins doubts described any real thirteenth-century duty at all (McKenna 2003, pp. 104-107). We accept all of this. The point to hold is that the branch has transformed the attested office in two directions at once, requiring a virgin woman, and attaching to her presence a significance the law knows nothing of. That double transformation is a fact requiring explanation, and it prevents the law-code parallel from being treated as a sufficient account of the footholder. Four accounts of it are on the table, and this essay adds no fifth. The sovereignty reading explains the woman as a token of the land. Hughes suggests that the author took an ordinary office and imbued it with a deeper significance, creating a kind of affliction on Math for the purposes of his tale (Hughes, note to lines 5/6; McKenna reports him at p. 107 as attributing the female footholder itself to the author, but his own words attribute the significance). Harris suggests that practice may itself have evolved, replacing a male officer with a girl (cited by McKenna, p. 107). McKenna suggests the change may have raised a knowing laugh at the expense of a real male officer or a lecherous king (p. 107). An earlier draft of this essay proposed a fifth, that the transformation participates in the branch’s preoccupation with sex, gender, reproduction and bodily transgression, the same preoccupation that punishes Gwydion and Gilfaethwy by turning them into breeding beasts. That proposal is withdrawn, not because it is implausible but because it is not this essay’s to make: Section 3 declines to admit the branch’s literary characterisation of Math to the reconstruction, and the footholder belongs to that characterisation. A reading of the office is an account of what the branch does with the figure, which is a different inquiry from the one pursued here, and one this essay has no need to settle in either direction. Readers pursuing it should begin with Valente, “Gwydion and Aranrhod: Crossing the Borders of Gender in Math,” *Bulletin of the Board of Celtic Studies* 35 (1988), 1-9, and with Sullivan, “Inheritance and Lordship in Math,” *THSC* (1990), 45-63.↵
6. The sceptical position that bears directly on this essay is the anti-nativist critique, whose fullest statement is McCone, *Pagan Past and Christian Present in Early Irish Literature*, Maynooth Monographs 3 (Maynooth, 1990). Its force is that the medieval texts are the work of Christian literati throughout, so that their contents can safely be taken only as a past mediated, and possibly created, in Christian terms; on that view the inference from a medieval tale to pre-Christian belief is not merely uncertain but methodologically unlicensed. Wooding, “Reapproaching the Pagan Celtic Past: Anti-Nativism, Asterisk Reality and the Late-Antiquity Paradigm,” *Studia Celtica Fennica* 6 (2009), 61-74, surveys the resulting shift and its limits. This is a stronger objection than the one an earlier draft of this note cited, and it is met here not by rebuttal but by scope: this essay does not infer a pre-Christian belief from a medieval tale in a single step. It establishes distributions in the surviving text, argues that they cohere, and marks the further step to a diminished god as conviction rather than demonstration (Section 5). A reader persuaded by McCone may accept everything in Sections 2 and 4 and decline Section 3, and the essay is written so that this is possible. The diminishment frame is a prior premise rather than a textual hypothesis, so it does not take a falsifier of the kind Sections 2 and 4 state, since a premise cannot be tested by the evidence whose interpretation it conditions without circularity. What it can be given, and is given here, is a defeater. The reconstruction should be abandoned if the features it treats as anomalous can be adequately accounted for as medieval literary creation, courtly convention, borrowing, or ordinary magical-story material, with no unexplained residue left over; or if external evidence positively locates their origin within the medieval literary environment. McCone’s force is precisely that Christian literati were capable of producing the very material a reconstruction might mistake for inheritance, and that possibility is what the defeater is framed to catch. The distinct “Celtosceptic” debate over the definition of “Celtic” and “Celts” is a different argument and is not relied on here; see Sims-Williams, “Celtomania and Celtoscepticism,” *Cambrian Medieval Celtic Studies* 36 (Winter 1998), 1-35.↵

7. Math's attribute is stated at lines 25-27 of Hughes's edition (Davies pp. 47-48; Gruffydd p. 5): whatever whisper passes between people, however quietly spoken, if the wind meets it, he will know of it. Hughes glosses *kynedyf* as "magical peculiarity/characteristic," and gives as comparanda the cauldron Bendigeidfran gives Matholwch in *Branwen* and Ceï's special attributes in *Culhwch*, both supernatural properties (Hughes, note to line 25). The word therefore names a marked supernatural property rather than a trait of character, which is the sense in which this essay uses it. The tradition's own parallel is the Coraniaid of *Cyfranc Lludd a Llefelys*, who likewise hear the slightest whisper spoken between men (CLlaLl 32-5, cited by Hughes at the same note; ed. Roberts, 1975, lines 32-35, where Roberts notes the similarity to Math's *cynneddf* at p. 9). Gruffydd reads the attribute as marking Math an "other-world sorcerer," "because no word that the wind meets is unknown to him." Two points are recorded here because the argument was at one stage tempted by each. The clause *o ry kyuarfo y guynt ac ef* is conditional in form, and it is tempting to press the condition as a limitation of scope; the Coraniaid parallel tells against that, since there the same conditional sits inside an explicitly total claim, and nothing in this essay rests on the grammar. And Hughes observes that the text gives no explanation of how Math came to possess the characteristic (see his "The king's nephew," *150 Jahre "Mabinogion"*, 55-65, at 58).↵
8. The rod-test of Aranrhod: Math bids Aranrhod step over his rod to prove the virginity she has claimed, whereupon she at once bears Dylan and leaves behind the small form that becomes Lleu, the false claim undone in the very act of testing it. *Pedeir Keinc y Mabinogi* (Williams 1930), Fourth Branch; the Welsh text and a translation are also given in Gruffydd 1928, pp. 17-19; trans. Davies 2007. Line references are to Hughes's critical edition throughout; the corresponding references in McKenna are to Hughes's earlier Aberystwyth edition of 2000 and do not agree with them, so the two are never mixed here.↵
9. The transformation of Gwydion and Gilfaethwy: Math drives the two, three years running, through the forms of deer, boar, and wolf, compelled to couple and to bear the offspring Hyddwn, Hychddwn, and Bleiddwn. *Pedeir Keinc y Mabinogi* (Williams 1930), Fourth Branch; the Welsh text and a translation are also given in Gruffydd 1928, pp. 15-17; trans. Davies 2007. Line references are to Hughes's critical edition throughout; the corresponding references in McKenna are to Hughes's earlier Aberystwyth edition of 2000 and do not agree with them, so the two are never mixed here.↵
10. McKenna 2003, p. 114 and n. 65. The joke she identifies turns on Gilfaethwy's refusal to confess, "*Yr hynn a deryw ymi ny frwytha ymi y adef y neb*," on the ground that Math will hear of it, followed at once by Gwydion's speaking the matter aloud, "*caru Goewin yd wyt ti*," without visible consequence. It should be recorded that the branch's own character thus glosses the attribute in the widest sense, as hearing whatever is said. That gloss is the text's only internal statement of what the *cynneddf* amounts to, and it is evidence for the attribute's reach rather than against it; what it does not settle, and what Gilfaethwy has no occasion to consider, is whether hearing entails acting. The argument of Section 2 is drawn so as not to depend on the question either way.↵
11. Hughes, edition of *Math Uab Mathonwy*, note to line 25. His conclusion in full is that it appears Gwydion does not fear the consequences of speaking these words aloud. He draws no inference about whether Math heard them.↵
12. At line 543 the narrator says the tale went to Math, *yna y chwedyl a aeth at Math uab Mathonwy*, at the point where Blodeuwedd's betrayal and Lleu's fall become known to him. An exhaustive classification of every instance of Math's knowledge in the branch returns the same result throughout: he learns by report or by enacted test, and there is no instance of his knowing a thing spoken elsewhere that no one carried to him.↵
13. McKenna 2003, pp. 116-117, drawing on Stacey, "King, Queen, and Edling in the Laws of Court," in *The Welsh King and His Court*, ed. Charles-Edwards and others (2000), for the Laws as a vehicle through which jurists expressed their thinking on Welsh politics, aiming not merely to reflect historical reality but to reshape it.↵
14. McKenna, "Revising Math: Kingship in the Fourth Branch of the Mabinogi," *Cambrian Medieval Celtic Studies* 46 (2003): 95-118. Her stated aim is to revise the assessments of Roberts, Davies and Bollard, on which Math is magnanimous, fair and just, an ideal king, and to show instead the blemishes on the king's face (p. 95); her thesis is that he is better read as a lord in the process of becoming what he needs to be than as one who represents ideal kingship from the outset (p. 96), on the model of her readings of Pwyll (1980) and Manawydan (1999). The argument runs through the anomalous opening formula (pp. 97-99), the word *gwastadrwydd* and its negative colouring in *Ystoria Gereint uab Erbin* (pp. 99-101), a consuetudinal reading of *ny bydei uyw* (p. 102), and the Laws of Court on the *troediog* (pp. 104-107), to the diagnosis of Math's affliction as a moral one, a species of *acedia* (p. 108). On the sovereignty reading she is expressly resistant, finding Carey's account attractive but circular, since it is the text alone that provides the evidence of the myth which then explains the text (p. 103). Two of those steps are contested by the editor of the text, and one is corroborated, which a reader should know. Hughes glosses *y wastatrwyl* concretely, as "his permanent residence," citing McKenna at 99-102 for the alternative rather than adopting it; and he explains Math's not making the circuit of Gwynedd by the affliction itself rather than by any moral failing, so that where she reads sloth he reads incapacity (Hughes, notes to line 10). Against that, he takes the position of *penteulu* to be held

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15. McKenna 2003, p. 117, the closing paragraph, where the resources of native tradition are said to be harnessed to urging rulers to move carefully, prudently and with dignity through the politics of the period.↵
16. McKenna 2003, pp. 104-107; see note 4 for the detail and for the concession made there.↵
17. McKenna 2003, p. 115.↵
18. Ownership and operation are kept distinct. Seven of the eight operations are Math’s; the eighth, at line 597, is Gwydion’s, restoring Lleu from the eagle with the same instrument. The distribution is a fact about the wand and not about who holds it, and the argument does not need the stronger claim. Lines 91 and 96-97, *a rithassei ef o’r madalch*, and *ny phara yr hut namyn o’r pryt pwy gilyd*. The transformations effected by the wand are at lines 203, 205, 220, 234, 237, 251, 266 and 597, each holding until deliberately reversed, three of them for a year at a time.↵
19. On the novelty of the present reading, stated to the strength of the search actually run: no substantially similar interpretation was found in the English-language scholarship and bibliographical resources searched for this study, including CODECS and the accessible periodical literature. That search was not exhaustive of Welsh-language scholarship, nor of complete journal back-runs, and the claim is accordingly that no precedent was found rather than that none exists. On the Act of Truth, the pronouncement of truth that alters reality, see Dillon, “The Hindu Act of Truth in Celtic Tradition,” *Modern Philology* 44, no. 3 (February 1947), 137-40, and Watkins, *How to Kill a Dragon* (1995). Dillon’s four pages establish that early Insular tradition knows truth-utterance as efficacious and that the motif has an Indo-European reach; they do not establish anything about Welsh material or about Math, and are not cited here as doing so. His broader case for the archaism of Insular tradition is at “The Archaism of Irish Tradition,” *Proceedings of the British Academy* 33 (1947), 245-64, and is itself subject to the caution in note 5. Its royal form, *fir flathemon*, receives its classic expression in *Audacht Morainn* (ed. Kelly 1976); see also O Cathasaigh, *The Heroic Biography of Cormac mac Airt* (1977), and Jaski, *Early Irish Kingship and Succession* (2000). The tradition also knows a non-royal *fir filed*, the truth of poets, which is why “truth” in this material cannot be assumed a royal property alone. On novelty: we have found no previous interpretation that makes truth the organising principle of Math’s character, and none that connects Math to the Act of Truth or *fir flathemon*, in the literature so far searched, which comprises web-accessible bibliographies, the CODECS and CMCS indices, and standard reference works, and not yet a full JSTOR or specialist pass. The novelty claim is therefore provisional and should be stated with its scope.↵
20. McKenna 2003, p. 115.↵
21. McKenna 2003, p. 113 and nn. 60-61, gathering the Triads, the Book of Taliesin, the *Cywyddwyr*, and the *cyfarwyddiaid*; see Bromwich, *Triodd Ynys Prydein*, pp. 448-50, and Hughes’s edition, pp. viii-xii. This is the one residue attested substantially outside the branch, which is why it is given first among them.↵
22. The condition is *ny bydei uyw* unless his feet were in a maiden’s lap, except when the turmoil of war prevented him (Davies p. 47). Gruffydd, Jones and Jones, Ford and Davies all render it existentially; Gruffydd alone records that his rendering is an interpretation of a phrase that is not transparent (Gruffydd 1928, p. 54, quoted by McKenna, p. 102 n. 31). McKenna proposes the consuetudinal past, “would not live unless” or “was not in the habit of living without,” and reads the requirement as a taste for ease rather than a taboo (p. 102). She does not establish that reading either, and offers it against the weight of the translation tradition. Since a literary use for the condition is available on her account and an inherited one on ours, and since nothing in this essay depends on the outcome, the residue is marked undecided.↵
23. The matronymic reading is Bromwich’s (*Triodd Ynys Prydein*, 2nd edn, Cardiff, 1978, p. 448). The doubled-name reading, that Mathonwy is a non-person and merely a doublet of Math’s own name, is advanced by Davies (*Mabinogion*, note to p. 47, at pp. 239-240), who compares the invented father-names Sugn son of Sugnedydd and Drem son of Dremidydd in “How Culhwch Won Olwen”; Davies also notes the matrilinear indications (Gwydion and Gilfaethwy named for their mother Don, Lleu inheriting Gwynedd through Math’s sister), so both options are live in the scholarship.↵